

Doesn't YouTube and Google also use a ton of water to function, as they are (or were before Chat) the biggest search engines in existence? Why is ChatGPT/Open Source AI different?

Posted by u/butwhatifly_ • 0 points • 14 comments

This feels so dumb but I genuinely don't understand how this form of tech is that different from a fundamental usage of resources?

Open source AI has obviously a terrible reputation based on what it does to the environment.

Comments

u/itz_zoroonyt • 1 points • 2026-04-01 00:24 UTC

Almost everything uses our water btw OUR WATER

u/thuiop1 • 2 points • 2025-12-31 06:55 UTC

Video streaming is very bad for the environment for sure. But it got widespread before we really cared about such things and now it is a very hard to shake-off habit. Also video streaming is heavily optimized whereas LLMs are typically the least efficient way to perform a given computing task (e.g. searching for information).

u/butwhatifly_ • 1 points • 2025-12-31 11:27 UTC

This makes sense, thank you

u/DOOManiac • 3 points • 2025-12-30 02:28 UTC

The workload done by these servers is incredibly simplistic compared to an LLM. Trolling a site, getting the gist of its content, ranking - all complicated stuff. But resource-wise, you can do that 1,000,000 times faster than training an LLM. And it scales out easily to a variety of devices at different speeds and power requirements. Whereas AI needs bonkers amount of high end, expensive GPU compute.

u/Express_Wrongdoer140 • 2 points • 2026-01-01 18:00 UTC

The scale is just nuts though - like Google processes billions of searches daily but training GPT-4 probably used more compute in a few months than Google's entire search infrastructure uses in

years. It's not just about the water cooling, it's that AI training is basically trying to simulate a brain with millions of expensive graphics cards running 24/7 for months

u/TheDonnARK • -1 points • 2025-12-30 02:05 UTC

Google and YouTube certainly use their fair share of water. But they provide actual content and stable, predictable service that goes beyond chatbots that agree with your obvious intentional lies for the sake of getting one more month of subscription fees.

The amount of power to send, retrieve, and receive discrete chunks of data like stored videos, chats, and emails is much lower than a simple chatgpt query that has to use complex machine learning algorithms and access its scraped and ripped library of cause-and-effect patterns until it recognizes one that lines up with what you are asking, then cross-check against a list of no-go topics and likely a list of basic knowledge among others, and then fart out an answer telling you that yes you SHOULD use fucking Elmer's Glue on your pizza as a binder for the mozzarella cheese, or that actually, Elon Goddamn Musk is more fit than LeBron James.

u/Linkpharm2 • 4 points • 2025-12-30 01:28 UTC

> Open source AI has obviously a terrible reputation based on what it does to the environment.

Generally open source is significantly better. Closed source is usually for profit, see ChatGPT. Open source are things like siglip, qwen (some), openpose, GANs, deepseek, and other light things that don't require (some because of the lack of demand alone) the amount of power datacenters do.

Water isn't a significant concern here. Datacenters return the water they use, and in the first place don't use a large amount.

Datacenters: 500 billion gallons/year
Leaky pipes (US): 2.5 trillion gallons/year
Meat production: 44 trillion gallons/year

Power is another story and it's up to you if datacenters are worth the power they use.

u/bt21bts8 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 19:41 UTC

>Datacenters return the water they use

Oh so they're re-using water?

u/Linkpharm2 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 19:48 UTC

No, return.

u/bt21bts8 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 21:12 UTC

So aren't they still using up water? 500 billion gallon/year is still used even if they return it no?

u/Linkpharm2 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 21:24 UTC

When it's returned, it is recycled.

u/bt21bts8 • 1 points • 2026-03-03 21:50 UTC

Then the water is re-used💩 then can't they just re-use that same

water?

u/butwhatifly_ • 2 points • 2025-12-30 01:32 UTC

Ohhh interesting! Ngl I thought ChatGPT was just an example of open source so I opted to use it bc I know there are other brands if you will, not just blaming chat.

Also, thank you for those numbers!! So... do we know how much water data centers (or whatever other things they may be called) for Google would use?

I'm just trying to figure out why ChatGPT is getting such a bad rap.

u/Linkpharm2 • 1 points • 2025-12-30 01:35 UTC

I don't recall the numbers for google's datacenters. Google is also a huge company. They have vertex which is used by other companies which gets complicated fast. Are you trying to figure out what's the server returning the query? Or the servers that run inference on the LLM. Or maybe training? Orrr something else.

Most of the numbers are guesses at best.

u/SlasherMcGurk17 • 5 points • 2025-12-30 01:25 UTC

It's not different! Google uses a TON of water too.

u/butwhatifly_ • 2 points • 2025-12-30 01:26 UTC

But no one ever complained about its impact on the environment?? Why now?

u/notextinctyet • 4 points • 2025-12-30 01:54 UTC

The amount of power used by a single search is orders of magnitude smaller than the amount of power used by a single AI query. Google uses a ton of water because it's very widely used, not because it's inefficient.

u/mulch_v_bark • 7 points • 2025-12-30 01:41 UTC

People have been complaining about data centers' environmental effects for decades. You can agree or disagree with particular arguments that people have made about them. Personally I agree with some and disagree with others. But no matter what, this has been an issue for a long time.

AI is generally much more computationally intense per query than search is, so it changes the scale of the problem. That's why we hear *more* about it. But the problem is old.

u/Namika • 6 points • 2025-12-30 01:36 UTC

People need Gmail and Google Maps.

People don't need AI slop.

u/Yvonxxyx • 3 points • 2025-12-30 01:21 UTC

Not dumb at all! A lot of people don't realize AI training can use huge amounts of electricity and resources.

u/butwhatifly_ • 1 points • 2025-12-30 01:25 UTC

Thanks! Can you elaborate a bit on why it's different from the other huge companies in the search engines space?